

**MYSTERY
SHOPPING
ASSESSMENT
2026 Q3
REPORT**

BACKGROUND

A 2024 study revealed an HIV prevalence of 27% among MSM and 54% among transwoman respectively. This high prevalence is associated with reduced accessing of health services by MSM, trans persons and other key populations due to high levels of stigma and discrimination.

The experiences of discrimination are undergirded by a legal system which criminalizes consensual same-sex intimacy between adults and fails to adequately and comprehensively protect MSM, trans persons, PLHIV and other key populations from all forms of discrimination. The UNAIDS societal enabler 10-10-10 targets will not be met in the context of Jamaica, unless the current legal system undergoes reform.

These experiences also result in a high level of internal stigma among PLHIV. In the People Living with HIV Stigma Index Jamaica published in 2020, more than half (53%) of PLHIV reported feeling guilty, ashamed, worthless, and/or dirty, 74% noting that they find it difficult to tell others of their HIV status, while 81% reported that they hide their HIV status from others.

The EFAF-commissioned 2024 LGBTQ+ Jamaican Needs Assessment Survey, only 16% of LGBTQ+ Jamaicans feeling safe living in Jamaican with the level safety experienced being different based on the setting, based on the Needs Assessment. Only 29% of LGBTQ+ Jamaicans deem public spaces as safe, 33% faith-based spaces, while 43% of LGBTQ+ people deem health spaces as safe or very safe. Additionally, more often than not, MSM and trans persons were not comfortable expressing their sexual orientation and gender identity in public health spaces.

Since 2019, EFAF has undertaken mystery shopping exercises across health facilities island-wide. Based on the reports we have received, there has been improvement in service delivery at these facilities, however, continued engagement of healthcare facilities is necessary to ensure that there is continued improvement of service delivery to key populations.

The Q1 2026 Reports focused on eight (8) facilities in Southern and Southeast health regions. This report reassesses those eight facilities to see if there are any differences since the last round concluded on March 31.

METHODOLOGY

Selection of Sites

The sites that were assessed in Q1 were reassessed to determine whether there had been any shifts in the experiences within the facility.

Recruitment Strategy

Mystery shoppers from the previous assessments were re-engaged with a few new additions who were not able to participate previously.

Training

An online training of mystery shoppers was executed on July 19, 2026, with eighteen (18) participants. The training included basic information about HIV, protocol for an HIV test, any MOHW specific HIV testing rules, and examples of what a high-quality testing experience would include. Mystery shoppers were instructed to be honest about their sexual behaviours during their visits and to avoid creating false personas.

SITE VISITS

Pre-Visit Procedure

Before mystery shopping commenced, the Programmes and Advocacy Manager determined which site the mystery shoppers would visit. Each participant was assigned no more than three (3) treatment sites to conduct assessments from August 10 to 28, 2026.

All but one testing site was shopped three times by three different mystery shoppers on different days and times. Shoppers completed the validated site assessment survey immediately after the visit. The assessment survey collected information on the duration of the visit, the clinic environment, and how well privacy and confidentiality were maintained. Shoppers also evaluated the providers' discussions regarding relationship context, testing and counselling assessment, safer sex recommendations, and PrEP-related discussions.

At the end of each assessment survey, shoppers were given the opportunity to provide an overall qualitative impression of their experience at the site. These open text fields enabled the shopper to describe how they felt about the site and the provider; anything notable that had occurred over the course of the visit, be it positive or negative; and any other information deemed pertinent to the experience that was not already captured by the quantitative assessment.

RESULTS

Eighteen (18) mystery shoppers completed assessments during this exercise, conducting a total of twenty-four (24) visits across eight (8) distinct facilities. Of the eighteen shoppers, twelve (12) were assigned male at birth and six (6) were assigned female at birth. Of those assigned male, six (6) identified as cisgender gay men, one (1) identified as cisgender bisexual men, three (3) identified as trans women and two (2) identified as being non-binary/gender non-conforming. Of those assigned female, one (1) identified as a cisgender lesbian, three (3) identified as trans men and the other two (2) identified as straight. Concerning age distribution, the ages of the shoppers fell within the following bands: 18–24 (n=6), 25–34 (n=10), 35–44 (n=1) and 45–54 (n=1). Using a scale of one to five with one being not comfortable at all and five meaning extremely comfortable, mystery shoppers gave facilities in the Southern and Southeast region an overall average comfort score of 3.42 out of 5, just above "somewhat comfortable" on the scale. This is a higher rating than the 3.25 rating given to these facilities in the Q1 assessment and to the 3.29 average score for the facilities in Western and Northeastern regions. This shows an upward trend in some respects for the facilities, with some facilities significantly outperforming others. Chart 1 shows the average comfort rating for each facility relative to the overall average. Two facilities were scored above average. Linstead, which received a perfect comfort score, had an outsized impact on the overall average, without which the average comfort score would be 3.19, lower than the previous assessment.

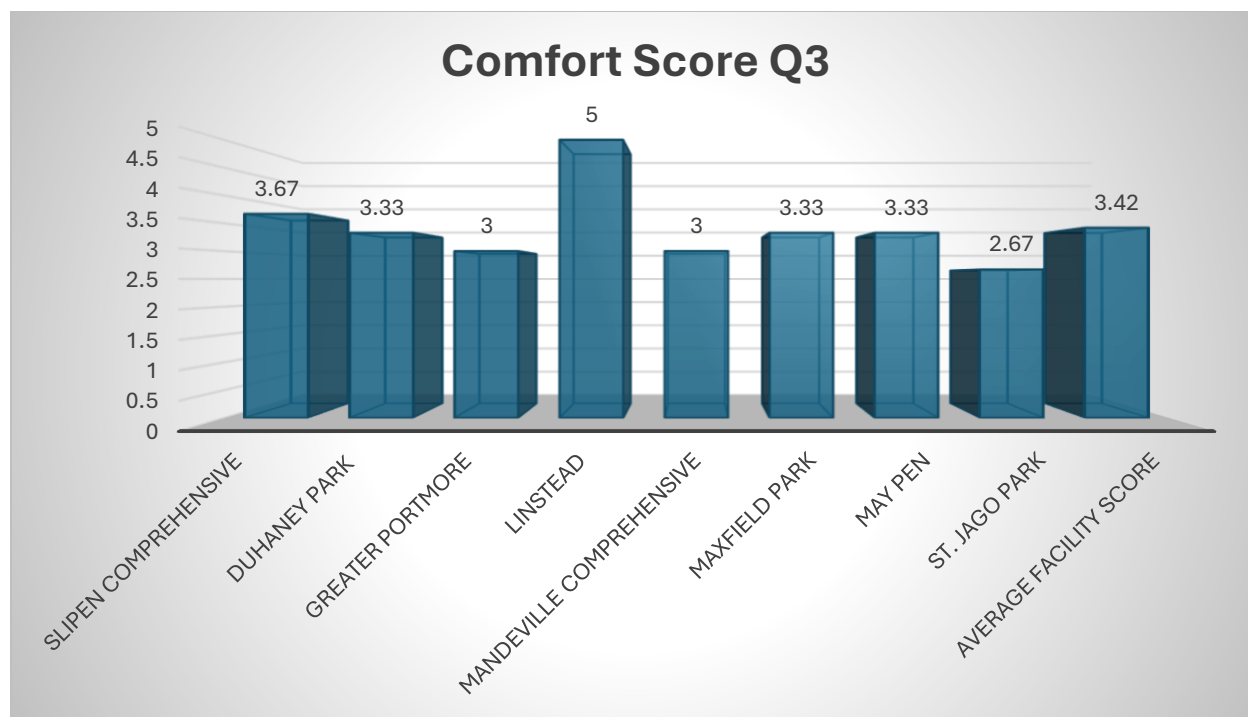


Chart 1

When comparing these results to their previous assessment, four facilities improved in their average comfort scores: Slipen Comprehensive, Duhaney Park, Linstead and May Pen Health Centres. At Greater Portmore, Mandeville Comprehensive and Maxfield Park Health Centres, their average comfort had a slight decrease. St. Jago Park remained the same. Important to note, only one health centre fell below the “somewhat comfortable” designation – St. Jago, whereas three were so rated in the Q1 assessment. This suggest that while the scores may shift upwards and downwards, collectively, the health centres in Southern and Southeast regions are experiencing a marginal improvement. Chart 2 shows the comparison between average comfort rating for each facility across both assessments.

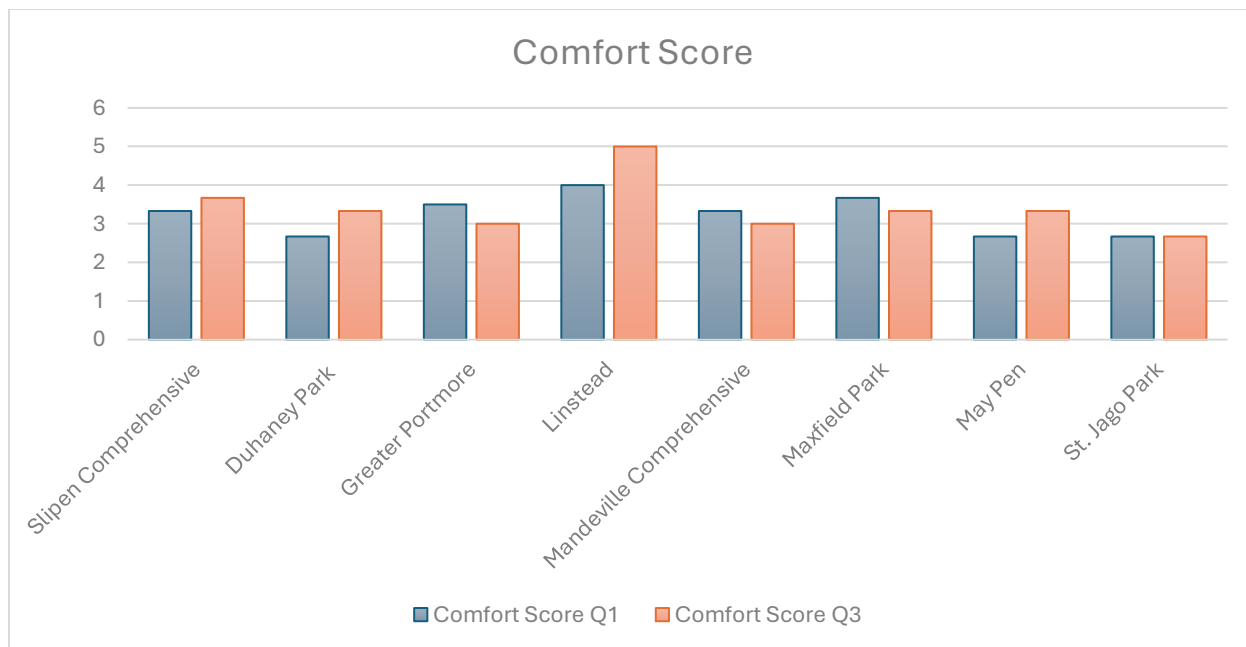


Chart 2

At each facility, five categories of service providers were assessed for satisfactory treatment – security guards, administrative clerks, nurses, doctors and student doctors. The shoppers were invited to rate the experience with one being “very dissatisfied” and five being “very satisfied.” On average, each category of service provider scored between neutral and satisfactory, with nurses having an average score of 4.04 as the highest rated service providers and student doctors with the lowest rating of 3.63.¹ Important to note, the lowest average save for student doctors, who were only engaged by eight shoppers, was security guards at 3.96, suggest that by and large the staff experience was very satisfactory to the shoppers. Chart 3 shows the comparative averages.

¹ Please note the sample for student doctors were low. Only 8 shoppers were engaged by student doctors.

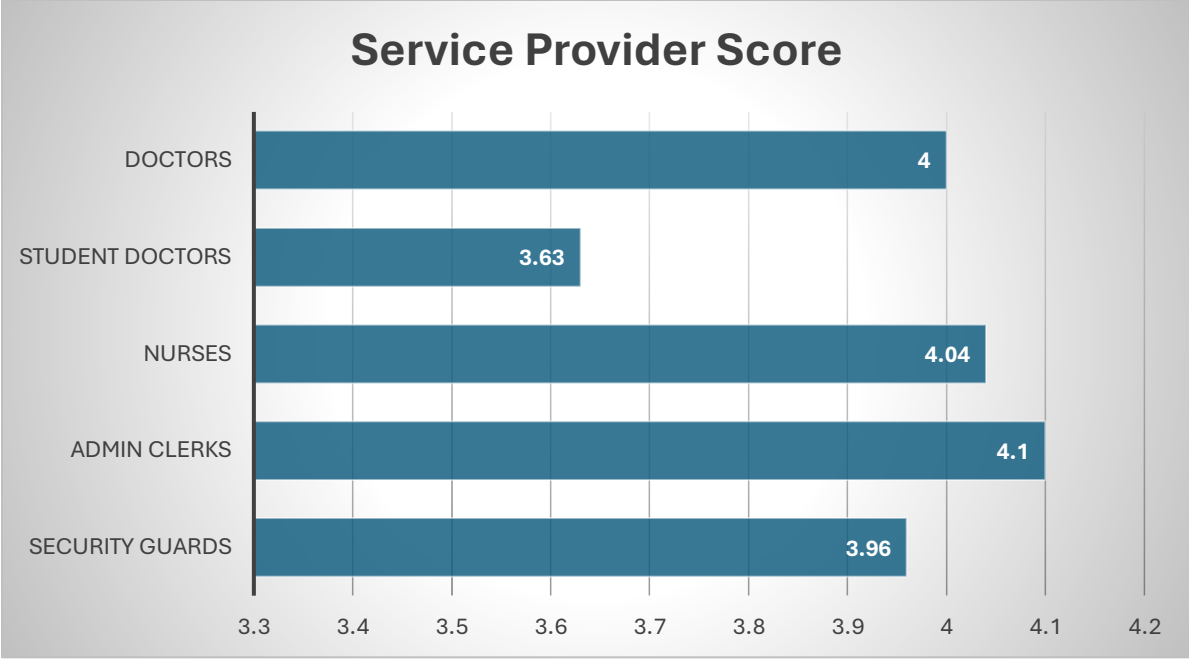


Chart 3

The experience of shoppers at each facility is explored in more detail below.

Slipen Road Comprehensive Health Centre

The Slipen Road Comprehensive Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by a cisgender gay man, a cisgender lesbian woman and a non-binary male person. All three went for HIV testing. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to extremely comfortable, for an average rating of 3.67, above the average of all facilities assessed. The score was slightly higher than the previous assessment (3.33/5).

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, the experiences were varied with one shopper finding it difficult, one finding it very easy and the third being neutral. While none of the shoppers felt inappropriate questions were asked by the administrative staff, the gay male shopper perceived a negative attitude from the security guard. Similarly, on the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, most shoppers felt the staff was respectful, but the gay male also perceived negative attitudes from the nurse,

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 3.33/5 (neutral). For the admin clerk, the average was also 3.67 (neutral to satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 4 (satisfied), for the doctor the average score was 3 (neutral) and for the student doctor, the average score was 4 (satisfied). Only two shoppers were seen by a doctor or student doctor. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff, but the negative attitude from the nurse was noted.

The shoppers all agree that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality; none felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them and none observed others being treated poorly. Two shoppers had a positive experience with both frontline and medical staff but as noted, one had a negative experience with both, noting that once he self-identified as gay, the face of the doctor became unpleasant.

Overall, two shoppers were positive in their assessment of the facility and one had an overall negative experience. Consequently, only two would recommend the facility to another community member. All shoppers recommended reducing waiting times, and there were additional recommendations to change/train staff and improve maintenance and cleanliness of the facility.

Duhaney Park Health Centre

The Duhaney Park Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by two cisgender gay men and a trans man. The two gay men went for HIV/STI testing and the trans man accessed general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to very comfortable, for an average rating of 3.33, above the average of all facilities assessed. The score was higher than the previous assessment (2.67/5).

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, two of the shoppers were neutral and one shopper felt it was easy. Two shoppers rated the staff as being professional, noting that one case of unrelated question was helpful small talk to create a friendly environment. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, two shoppers felt the staff was respectful and one felt they were not respectful, describing them as unhelpful and unprofessional when being asked questions.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 3.33/5 (neutral). For the admin clerk, the average was also 4 (satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was also 4, for the doctor the average score was 3.67 (neutral – satisfied) and for the student doctor, the singular score was 4. Only two (2) shoppers interacted with an admin clerk. Two shoppers noted that no unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff, however the trans shopper was asked about their transition journey but noted it came from a place of genuine professional curiosity.

The shoppers mostly agree that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality (one was neutral); one felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory, but none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. No shopper observed others being treated poorly. Two shoppers had a positive experience with both frontline and medical staff but as noted, one had a negative experience with frontline staff from whom he perceived negative attitudes during the interaction.

Overall, two shoppers were positive in their assessment of the facility and one had an overall negative experience. Consequently, only two would outright recommend the facility to another community member and one shopper, a gay man, only saying maybe – for testing services. The shoppers recommended inclusive signage and posters and inclusive intake forms and continued training. One suggested changing frontline staff to more friendly persons.

Greater Portmore Health Centre

The Greater Portmore Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by two cisgender gay man and a transgender man. One of the gay men and the trans man went for HIV testing and the other gay man went for general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility was unanimously somewhat comfortable, for an average rating of 3, slightly lower than the average of all facilities assessed. The score was lower than the previous assessment (3.5/5).

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, all three shoppers were neutral. All shoppers noted that the administrative staff were professional. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, two shoppers felt the staff were respectful however the trans man disagreed, experiencing misgendering even after providing their correct pronouns.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 4/5 (satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was 3.5 (neutral – satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 3.33 (neutral), for the doctor the average score was 4 and for the student doctor, the singular score was 3. Only two (2) shoppers engaged an admin clerk and only two were seen by a doctor. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

Only one shopper felt that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality, the others were neutral. None felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. However, one shopper noted that they saw others being treated poorly/differently. When assessing their experience with frontline workers, while the shoppers generally felt the workers were respectful, one noted that communication could be better and another noted that a customer service rep had an unwelcoming demeanour.

Overall, the shoppers were positive in their assessment of the facility, however the misgendering experience by the trans shopper was noted as a negative. The nurse elected to only use the shopper's name after being corrected twice on the pronouns. Additionally, one shopper noted there was no water at the facility and another reiterated the unpleasant demeanour of customer service staff. No shopper would outright recommend the facility to other community members. Several recommendations to do staff training on general customer service and gender diversity as well as infrastructural improvements.

Linstead Health Centre

The Linstead Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by a cisgender gay man, a transgender woman and a cisgender straight woman. The two women went for HIV/STI testing and the gay man accessed general health services. Generally, the shoppers were unanimous in their rating of comfort in the facility, as being extremely comfortable, for a perfect score of 5, above the average of all facilities assessed. The score was higher than the previous assessment (4/5), which was already a strong performance.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, all shoppers found it very easy. No shopper felt that they were asked unrelated questions by the admin staff. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, all shoppers felt respected.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 3.67/5 (neutral - satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was 4.67 (satisfied – very satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 4.67, for the doctor, they received a perfect score of 5 and no student doctor was engaged during the assessment. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

All shoppers agreed that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality. No shopper felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and similarly, no shopper felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. None saw others being treated poorly. While all shoppers had positive experiences with the frontline workers, one shopper noted they had to wait an hour for their docket to be found.

Overall, all shoppers had a positive experience with the facility, with all indicating they would recommend the facility to another community member. However, the non-binary shopper who went for dental services had a negative experience and would not recommend as they noted rudeness from both the frontline staff and nurse. She noted that there was homophobia within the facility, likely from other service users. The recommendations made by the shoppers were to reduce waiting times and better records management. The facility is strongly encouraged to continue maintaining their standard of customer service.

Mandeville Comprehensive Clinic

The Mandeville Comprehensive Clinic was assessed three (3) times by a cisgender bisexual man, a transgender man and a male non-binary person. The trans man went for general health services, the bisexual man went for PrEP services and the non-binary person went for HIV testing. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to very comfortable, for an average rating of 3, slightly lower than the average of all facilities assessed. The score was slightly lower than the previous assessment (3.33/5).

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, all shoppers found this easy. All the shoppers agreed that the administrative staff were professional, and no unrelated questions were asked. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, all shoppers felt the staff were respectful.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 4.67/5 (satisfied – very satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was also 4.33 (satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 4 (satisfied), for the doctor the average score was 4.67 and for the student doctor, the singular score was 3.33. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

All shoppers felt that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality. None felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. None saw others being treated poorly/differently. When assessing their experience with frontline workers, all shoppers reported a positive experience.

Overall, the shoppers all had positive in their assessment of the facility, with the trans man noting that there were occasional discomforting stares. Notwithstanding this, no shopper would outright recommend the facility, with all of them only saying “Maybe.” The shoppers were not sure that other LGBTQ+ persons would have a similar experience, particularly the more visible ones. The recommendations made by the shoppers were to ensure consistent training, with a potential designated person for LGBTQ+ clients.

Maxfield Park Health Centre

The Maxfield Park Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by a cisgender bisexual man, a cisgender gay man and a cisgender straight woman. The straight woman went for HIV/STI testing and the queer men accessed general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged

from somewhat comfortable to very comfortable, for an average rating of 3.33, above the average of all facilities assessed. The score was slightly lower than the previous assessment (3.67/5).

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, the experiences of the shoppers varied with the bisexual man finding it difficult, the straight woman finding it easy and the gay man being neutral. No shopper felt they were asked any unrelated questions by the admin staff. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, all shoppers felt the staff was respectful.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 3/5 (neutral). For the admin clerk, the average was 3.67 (neutral - satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 3.33 (neutral), for the doctor the singular score was 4 (satisfied) and for the student doctor, the singular score was 2. The singular shopper who interacted with a doctor found them to be respectful. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

Two of the shoppers felt that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality, with the gay man being neutral. None of the shoppers felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and similarly, none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. The gay man shopper noted that they saw others being treated poorly. All of the shoppers had positive experiences with the frontline workers, save for one being given the wrong directions.

Overall, while the shoppers generally had positive experiences with the staff, two of them noted that the other services were either deliberately staring at persons leaving the HIV testing area or were actively belligerent towards one of the shoppers. Additionally, one of the shoppers found out that the doctor was not at the health centre after they arrived, while the facility was still open. None of the shoppers would outright recommend this facility, with only shopper saying they may recommend the facility. One shopper recommended more visible signage of testing and PrEP services and another recommended ensuring the doctor was present at all times during opening hours.

May Pen Health Centre

The May Pen Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by two transgender men and a cisgender bisexual man. They all went for general health services.

Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from somewhat comfortable to very comfortable, for an average rating of 3.33, above the average of all facilities assessed. This was noticeably higher than the previous assessment (2.67/5).

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, two shoppers found getting assistance easy while the third, the bisexual man, found it difficult. While none of the shoppers felt that they were asked unrelated questions by the admin staff, one of the trans men noted being questioned multiple times about the sex marker on their ID. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, the shoppers generally felt respected, however the trans man did note that where the sex marker on the ID was seen, the pronouns might not be respected.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 4/5 (satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was 4.5 (satisfied – very satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 4.33, for the doctor the average score was 4 and no shopper interacted with a student. All points of contact, on average, were ranked at least satisfied and no point of contact received an individual score lower than 3 from any shopper. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff, however an unpleasant facial expression was noted from a doctor as well as issues related to the pronouns of one of the trans man shoppers.

All shoppers agreed that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality. None of the shoppers felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory. None of the shoppers felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. None of the shoppers saw others being treated poorly. All shoppers had positive experiences with the frontline workers.

Overall, while the shoppers generally had positive experiences with the staff, concerns were raised about the set up of the facility, waiting times and possible discrimination at the hands of other service users. Also, one trans man shopper noted that the sex marker on the ID often raised challenging conversations. None of the shoppers would outright recommend the facility to another community member, all indicating maybe. None felt that they could guarantee safety for other community members. Shoppers recommended training for staff around gender diversity, a bigger waiting area and a zero tolerance for discrimination policy to reduce and respond to incidences of discrimination by other service users.

St. Jago Health Centre

The St. Jago Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by a cisgender gay man and two transgender women. They all went for HIV/STI testing. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to somewhat comfortable, for an average rating of 2.67, below the average of all facilities assessed. The score was consistent with the previous assessment (2.67/5).

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, the experiences of the shoppers varied with the gay man being neutral, one trans woman finding it easy and the other finding it difficult. No shopper felt they were asked any unrelated questions by the admin staff. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, all shoppers felt the staff was respectful. One trans woman felt once they self-identified, the service improved.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 4/5 (satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was 4.5 (satisfied – very satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 4.67 (neutral), for the doctor the singular score was 4.33 (satisfied) and for the student doctor, the singular score was 4.5. Only two shoppers engaged with an admin clerk or student doctor. All points of contact, on average, were ranked at least satisfied and no point of contact received an individual score lower than 3 from any shopper. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff, however one of the trans women shoppers felt the doctor was aggressive, but only became helpful once she realized that she was trans.

All shoppers felt that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality. None of the shoppers felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and similarly, none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. One of the trans women shoppers noted that they saw others being treated poorly. All of the shoppers had positive experiences with the frontline workers, however noted that security and some nurses treated others poorly.

Overall, while the shoppers generally had positive experiences with the staff, one noted that communication gaps and delays due to the absence of the doctor reduced the quality of the experience. Only two of the shoppers would outright recommend this facility, with the third saying maybe, as they had general feeling of unwelcome. The recommendations focused on improving

communication with patients, the need for customer service training and the need for more staff to handle the volume of clients.

CONCLUSION

The Q3 mystery shopping assessments have noted that some facilities continue to perform well, while others are inconsistent in their service delivery. There have been incremental shifts in the time between the Q1 assessments and this one. Some facilities have marginally higher scores and others have marginally lowers. The average comfort score across both assessments has shown marginal improvement: 3.25 in the Q1 report and 3.42 in this report.

Across 24 visits to 8 facilities, experiences varied, not only between sites but within the same facility depending on which staff member a patient encountered. Linstead Health Centre was unsurprisingly the strongest performer. Among the other facilities, there were no glaring issues as most of the negative experiences identified were subtle rather than overt forms of stigmatizing or discriminatory practices: attitudes shifts and temporary misgendering.

In this assessment, transgender and non-binary shoppers had less notable challenges when accessing services. However, the absence of a systemic approach to addressing trans healthcare will mean patients whose IDs don't match their gender presentation may be met with on the benign end, genuine professional curiosity but on the harmful end of the spectrum: misgendering and unpleasant facial expressions. While student doctors have the lowest scores as a category of service provider, the sample was much smaller than the other categories. By and large, the scores across the service provider categories suggest the staff are generally professional and hardly demonstrative discriminatory or stigmatizing behaviours, though positive reinforcement may be useful

An issue that this assessment has captured is the reality the experience of patients within public health is not only impacted by staff: frontline and medical, but also by other users. To illustrate, May Pen & St. Jago all had stellar scores for their staff at all services points but their overall comfort score was notably lower. Many LGBTQ+ persons are not only impacted by service providers but by how they are treated by fellow service users, particularly in a context of long waiting times. They are more exposed to the possibility of homophobia by actors outside of the control of the Ministry.

Similar to what was demonstrated in the Q2 assessments of Lucea and Falmouth where the scores suggested a culture of tolerance in those facilities, Linstead has demonstrated itself to be case of best practice in providing services to members of the LGBTQ+ community. A case study is being recommended to see how best they can be modelled across the regions. Potentially, this may be a growing trend as St. Jago and May Pen staff are making positive strides

Waiting times continue to be flagged as issues for shoppers, even where the facility received an overall positive assessment. As a longstanding issue in service delivery, it demands targeted interventions and resources. Especially as long waiting times increases the risk of LGBTQ+ clients facing homophobia from other service users, impacting the overall score of the facility.

Ultimately, the findings align with the Q1 and Q2 assessments, reflecting a healthcare environment where LGBTQ+ patients can access services but are not always guaranteed non-discriminatory services with consistency. This report, however, suggests that there may be a positive trend growing that may need to

be uplifted and modelled. Based on the experiences of the LGBTQ+ community across the selected health facilities, the following is being recommended:

- Implement mandatory LGBTQ+ inclusivity and gender identity training for all clinical and non-clinical staff across all facilities.
- Establish a formal, facility-wide policy requiring acceptance of patients' chosen names and stated pronouns in all interactions.
- Introduce anti-stigma training specifically addressing HIV and sexual health services to eliminate judgemental staff conduct.
- Strengthen accountability at all facilities through visible anti-discrimination commitments and accessible complaints mechanisms for LGBTQ+ patients.
- Develop a national framework to reduce patient waiting time in facilities.
- Train staff members to respond safely and effectively to instances of discrimination between service users and create punitive administrative measures for service users who engage in same.
- Conduct follow-up mystery shopping assessments at all facilities to measure progress, with an expanded pool of shoppers to ensure broader and more representative coverage.
- Through the Enabling Environment in Health and Client Services Division of MOHW, facility learning exchanges between facilities that perform well in the assessment and those that perform poorly, to encourage peer-to-peer learning.